

Turn Left for EXIT

After its worst performance in the Lok Sabha elections in 25 years, a mood of despair envelops the CPI(M) and Karat faces an escalating revolt

THE POLITBURO MEETS FOR THE POST-MORTEM



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| By Shafi Rahman |

Reason has always existed, as Karl Marx said, but not always in a reasonable form. "The favourable situation after the 14th Lok Sabha elections should be utilised to develop mass movements on political issues and to initiate struggles of different sections of people on their economic demands. Adopting this course will enable the party to advance," said the report of the 18th Party Congress which coincided with Prakash Karat's elevation as general secretary. Far from advancing, the CPI(M) has now been reduced to a rump with just 16 seats in Parliament after its worst-ever electoral performance that pushed it to the eighth largest party, down from third in the last Lok Sabha. There is a mood of impending crisis in the party and Karat, its

youngest-ever general secretary, is facing an escalating revolt.

Thanks to the nuclear deal and the backseat brakes he applied on economic reforms between 2004 and 2008, Karat was once rhapsodised as the champion of the national interest. Now the prominence of the CPI(M) is fading from the national scene and even from the mofussil soviets in Kerala and West Bengal. In its strongholds, the CPI(M) has lost the class war and by mixing Marx with Mayawati, it has lost the caste war too. The party is now split into camps with loyalties overlapping and concept of collective leadership is now just a cliché.

West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya's offer to quit after being steamrolled by the Trinamool Congress doesn't come as an isolated incident. Militant at-

tempts to solve Nandigram and Singur issues had triggered resignation offers from him earlier too, but this time it was the result of a feud within. Nirupam Sen, commerce and industries minister and Politburo member, a known Karat acolyte was the first to stand by the party boss by blaming the state leadership for the electoral fallout. The CPI(M) state boss, Biman Bose, hit back saying that the decision to cobble up the Third Front and the hurried decision to withdraw support to the UPA government led to the Left defeat. During the last few months, Karat aggressively pushed the Third Front as the only option by ruling out a repeat of 2004 when the Left gave outside support to the UPA government to keep the BJP at bay. "In 2009, an anti-BJP, non-Congress government will come to power in Delhi,"